

BUS 123 — Solving Business Problems with Technology · Fall 2026

INTRO-M01-L02

Introduction to Course and Expectations

PRE-READING · Reading
Material Only

Pre-Reading

Introduction to Course and Expectations

Gerrish School of Business · BUS123

CONNECT TO PRIOR KNOWLEDGE

In Lesson 1 you installed Microsoft 365, connected your Endicott OneDrive, and built your BUS123 folder structure. You now have the technical foundation in place. This lesson steps back to answer a bigger question: what is this course actually about, and what does it expect of you? Understanding the structure and standards of BUS123 before the first graded assignment is the same skill professionals use when they read a contract before signing it — it saves confusion later.

WHAT BUS123 IS — AND IS NOT

BUS123 is not a typing class, a software tutorial, or a survey of technology trends. It is a business problem-solving course that uses technology as its primary tool. Every module begins with a real business scenario — payroll, inventory, breakeven analysis, loan calculations — and asks you to build the solution in Excel, interpret the result, and communicate what it means.

The distinction matters because it changes how you should approach each assignment. You are not learning Excel for its own sake. You are learning to use Excel the way a finance analyst, operations manager, or business owner would — to answer a specific question under real constraints.

COURSE STRUCTURE — THREE TRACKS

BUS123 is organized into three sequential tracks. Each track builds on the previous one. You will work through all three over the course of the semester.

Track	Code	Focus	When
Introduction	INTRO	Course setup, software orientation, professional habits	Early semester
Excel Skills	EXCEL	Worksheets, formulas, functions, formatting, data management	Mid semester
Business Math	MATH	Payroll, discounts, markup/markdown, TVM, breakeven, taxes	Mid to late semester

CASE STUDY COMPANIES

Rather than using abstract numbers, every module in BUS123 is grounded in one of four fictional companies. These companies have real business contexts — they face payroll questions, inventory decisions, pricing challenges, and financial planning problems. You will encounter them repeatedly throughout the semester.

Company	Industry	Topics Associated With
Tidal Goods Co.	Retail	Inventory, COGS, markup and markdown

Meridian Advisory Group	Professional services	Payroll, TVM, interest, tax, loan math
Anchor & Oak Events	Event management	Breakeven, seasonal cash flow, labor costs
Harborside Medical Center	Healthcare	Data analysis, payer mix, payroll complexity

HOW EACH LESSON WORKS

Every lesson follows the same rhythm. Understanding this pattern before your first class will help you stay oriented throughout the semester.

Before class	Complete the pre-reading and the Canvas homework quiz. The quiz is due before the lesson begins — not after. This is not busywork: the concepts you read about are the concepts we will apply in class.
During class — lecture	The instructor introduces the concept through worked examples using the case study companies. Excel function syntax is shown first; manual math follows.
During class — workshop	You work through the in-class Excel activity independently or in pairs. This is where you apply what you just saw to a new scenario.
After class	Review your workbook, check your results against the formula reference card, and reach out if anything did not make sense before the next session.

HOMEWORK QUIZZES AND CANVAS

Each lesson has a homework quiz in Canvas. These quizzes replace written homework — there is no separate paper or document to submit. Here is what you need to know:

Question types: Multiple choice, true/false, fill-in-the-blank, and matching. Calculation answers must be entered in formatted form (e.g., \$1,102.50).

Attempts: You have up to 3 attempts. Your highest score is kept, but a penalty applies to attempts 2 and 3. First attempt is always full credit.

Hints: If you answer a question incorrectly, a general hint appears. Hints point you toward the method — they do not give away the answer.

Due dates: Each quiz has its own due date set by your instructor. Check Canvas before each class session.

✓ Strategy

Do the pre-reading carefully before attempting the quiz. Students who read first and quiz second consistently perform better on the first attempt — saving their retries for the questions that genuinely require more thought.

WHAT 'PROFESSIONAL USE' LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE

One of the central themes of BUS123 is the difference between casual and professional technology use. This distinction shows up in every module. Here are three concrete examples of what it means in this course:

Behavior	Casual	Professional
File naming	homework.xlsx	Reyes_Taylor_BUS123_Module01.xlsx
Formula use	Type the answer directly into the cell	Reference input cells in a formula so the result updates automatically
File submission	Attach the file to an email	Share the OneDrive link to the synced file
Error handling	Delete the error and retype a number	Trace the formula to find and fix the root cause

■ Academic Integrity and AI Policy

AI tools may not be used to complete homework quizzes, in-class Excel activities, or graded assessments unless your instructor explicitly states otherwise for a specific assignment. Using AI to generate answers you submit as your own work undermines the skill-building this course is designed to produce — and those skills will be tested on exams where AI is not available.

KEY VOCABULARY

Track

A grouping of related modules in BUS123. The three tracks are INTRO (orientation and setup), EXCEL (spreadsheet skills), and MATH (business math applications).

Module

A unit of instruction within a track, covering one major topic area. Modules contain one or more lessons and associated deliverables.

Lesson

A single class session and its associated materials: pre-reading, slides, in-class activity, and homework quiz.

Pre-Reading

A document assigned before each lesson that introduces key concepts, vocabulary, and formulas. Reading this before class is required — it is the foundation for both the homework quiz and the in-class work.

Homework Quiz

A per-lesson Canvas quiz that tests comprehension of the pre-reading. Replaces all written homework. Auto-graded with up to 3 attempts.

Canvas

The learning management system (LMS) used at Endicott College. All homework quizzes, grades, and course announcements are managed through Canvas.

Case Study Company

One of four fictional businesses used throughout BUS123 to ground calculations and examples in realistic business contexts.

Professional Operator

A person who uses technology tools deliberately, accurately, and efficiently to produce reliable business outputs — as opposed to a casual user who relies on intuition and workarounds.